



◁ **HIGH-ALTITUDE CAP**
In this false-color satellite image, part of the ice cap and some small lakes surrounding it are visible. Vegetation in nearby valleys appears red.

▽ **MOUNTAIN CACTI**
Various species of cacti grow in the high Peruvian Andes near the ice cap, including this variety in the *Tephrocactus* genus, often described as a mounding cactus.



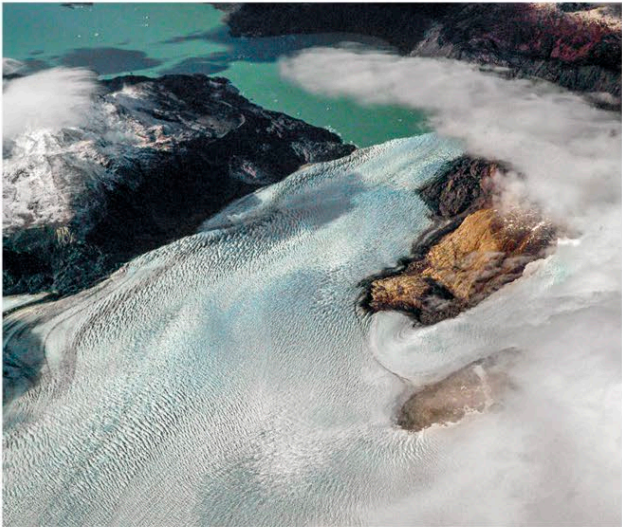
The Southern Patagonian Icefield

The world's second largest continuous icefield, stretching almost 230 miles (370 km) down the southern Andes



An icefield is a single, extensive mass of ice at high altitude that is partly hemmed in by mountains (in contrast, ice caps and ice sheets almost completely submerge a region). The Southern Patagonian Icefield is a remnant of the last glacial period, around 18,000 years ago, when all of southern Chile and Argentina was covered in a thick sheet of ice, over an area estimated to be about 185,000 square miles (480,000 square km). Today, it occupies an area less than 3 percent of that size. Mount Fitz Roy at 11,020 ft (3,359 m) and the volcano Lautaro at 11,886 ft (3,623 m) are two of the main peaks surrounded by the icefield.

▷ **OUTLET GLACIER**
The Gray Glacier is one of dozens of outlet glaciers that carry ice down from the icefield. Some end in glacial lakes, while others discharge icebergs into Chilean fjords (see p.116).



THE ICEFIELD AND ITS OUTLET GLACIERS

The Southern Patagonian Icefield is long and thin, with an average width of only about 22 miles (35 km). Some of the largest of its numerous outlet glaciers are marked here.

